



ACE

ALLIANCE FOR COLLECTIVE EMPOWERMENT AND DEVELOPMENT



PERSONAL & CONFIDENTIAL

Dear Mr. Smiley,

My name is Leandre Poplus, founder of the Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development, ACE. In 2006, you brought together some of the sharpest minds in Black America to write *The Covenant with Black America*, a national plan naming exactly what would help change the condition of the Black community, addressing areas including but not limited to healthcare, education, criminal justice, housing, and economics, with real action items attached to each. It became the number one book in the country. You revisited it ten years later, and again at twenty. Both times, you documented the same hard truth: the plan was right, and the ground had still fallen away beneath us. Black wealth evaporated further. The list of what needed fixing barely moved.

I am not writing to ask you for anything beyond your attention. I am asking you to consider a possibility the Covenant's own history may already be pointing you toward.

The Covenant was built, like nearly every serious plan before and since, on the assumption that the system could be made to respond, that if the right people named the right problems clearly enough, with enough data and enough moral weight behind them, the institutions responsible would eventually course correct. Twenty years of your own follow-up work says otherwise. Not because the Covenant was wrong. Because the system was never going to grade its own homework honestly.

ACE starts from a different premise. ***"A system built to exclude cannot be reformed into one that includes,"*** no matter how precisely the exclusion is documented. So instead of asking that system to finally course correct, again, ACE is a twenty-five-year plan to build, on land outside that system's control, the very institutions the Covenant called for two decades before ACE existed to build them, healthcare, education, housing, economic infrastructure, governed by the people those institutions actually serve.

You have already answered part of this on your own. You have spent decades building platforms that carried these conversations further than almost anyone else in American media, The Smiley Group, Smiley Books, three decades of independent broadcasting built and owned on your own terms. That body of work outlasts any single interview or headline. What I believe ACE offers is a place for that same instinct, build what you need rather than wait for permission, to extend one step further, into brick, land, and governance rather than pages and airtime alone.



For Our People, By Our People

founders@acecommunities.org • acecommunities.org



Please do not mistake me for an activist, a politician, or a leader in the traditional sense. I do not ascribe to any of those roles. I would describe myself as someone who has read the record you have kept for twenty years and concluded that the next covenant cannot only be a document. It has to be a place.

I am asking you to read this framework, challenge what should be challenged, and tell me plainly whether the plan you have followed and updated for two decades finally has the ground beneath it that it always needed.

The founding volume is enclosed. I would welcome a serious conversation about what it would take to make this real.

Respectfully,

Leandre Poplus

Founder

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